development in the Russian Far East. A number of other economic cooperation projects has been launched in nuclear energy, aerospace, and transportation.[17] Defence cooperation has scaled new technology levels, with recent agreements including the sophisticated S-400 air defence system, Su-35 aircraft, and joint development and manufacture of other military platforms.[18] In a demonstration of solidarity against challenges in their respective neighbourhoods, the two countries have held joint naval exercises in the South China Sea and the Baltic Sea. Their most recent joint military exercise in September 2018 (Vostok-2018) was a full-fledged “war games” exercise on land and sea, extending from the Pacific to the Arctic Ocean, with about 300,000 troops, including the largest-ever Chinese participation in a military exercise abroad. The Kremlin press spokesman described it as a demonstration of the military “alliance” of the two countries.

Adjusting to the Russia–US–China triangle

India’s foreign policy since 2000 has sought to concurrently develop relationships with Russia, the United States, and China in tune with contemporaneous opportunities. Each of these bilateral strands has intertwined with the other two in varying degrees over this period. While calibrating the course of these relations, an important Indian consideration has been their impact on narrowing the asymmetry of economic and military power with China, which has widened considerably since the 1990s.

Soviet/Russian-origin weapons and equipment form the backbone of India’s military capability – in quantitative terms, a dependence of 60 to 70 percent. They will remain in service for the next several decades, and India will need Russian support for ensuring operational serviceability,